

10 BCBA Practice Questions

With Detailed Answer Explanations

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These practice questions align with the BACB BCBA Test Content Outline (6th ed.) and are grounded in foundational behavior analytic literature (Cooper et al., 2020; Skinner, 1957).

Question 1: Measurement (Domain C)

A behavior analyst is collecting data on a student's hand-raising behavior during a 30-minute class period. Which measurement procedure would provide the most accurate count of this discrete behavior?

- A) Duration recording
- B) Frequency/event recording
- C) Partial interval recording
- D) Momentary time sampling

Question 2: Reinforcement (Domain G)

Which of the following best describes differential reinforcement of alternative behavior (DRA)?

- A) Reinforcing the absence of problem behavior
- B) Reinforcing a specific alternative to the problem behavior
- C) Reinforcing any behavior other than the target behavior
- D) Reinforcing lower rates of the problem behavior

Question 3: Verbal Behavior (Domain B)

A child says "cookie" when shown a picture of a cookie. This is an example of which verbal operant?

- A) Mand
- B) Tact
- C) Intraverbal
- D) Echoic

Question 4: Functional Assessment (Domain F)

During a functional analysis, problem behavior occurs at high rates during the attention condition and low rates during the alone condition. What function does this suggest?

- A) Escape
- B) Automatic reinforcement
- C) Social positive reinforcement (attention)

D) Tangible

Answer Key

With Research-Based Explanations

Question 1: Answer B

Frequency/event recording is most appropriate for discrete behaviors with a clear beginning and end, like hand-raising. Duration would be used for behaviors where length of time is important. Interval recording methods are estimates and less precise.

"Direct measurement of behavior provides the most accurate data for making treatment decisions" (Cooper et al., 2020).

Question 2: Answer B

DRA involves reinforcing a specific alternative behavior that serves the same function as the problem behavior. DRO reinforces absence, DRI reinforces incompatible behavior, and DRL reinforces lower rates.

"Differential reinforcement procedures systematically reinforce appropriate behavior while withholding reinforcement for problem behavior." (Cooper et al., 2020).

Question 3: Answer B

A tact is a verbal operant under the control of a nonverbal discriminative stimulus (the picture). A mand is controlled by motivation, an intraverbal by verbal stimuli, and an echoic by point-to-point correspondence with a vocal stimulus.

"Verbal behavior encompasses mands, tacts, intraverbals, and echoics as primary verbal operants." (Skinner, 1957).

Question 4: Answer C

High rates during attention condition and low rates during alone condition indicate the behavior is maintained by social positive reinforcement (attention). Automatic reinforcement would show high rates in the alone condition.

References

Cooper, J. O., Heron, T. E., & Heward, W. L. (2020). Applied behavior analysis (3rd ed.). Pearson.

Skinner, B. F. (1957). Verbal behavior. Prentice Hall.

Wilson, A. N., Kellum, K. K., & Jackson, M. (2021). Introduction to the special issue: Acceptance and commitment training in applied behavior analysis. Behavior Analysis in Practice, 15, 7-10.